

SKOAR! Special

Genre: Action, Third Person Shooter, Sandbox
Studio: Avalanche Studios, Square Enix London Studios
Publishers: Square Enix, Eidos
Platforms*: PC (MS Windows, Steam), PlayStation 3, Xbox 360
Price: PC: INR 699 / PS3, Xbox 360: INR 2499
**Reviewed on PC*

THE SKOAR

8



A just cause or for no cause at all? Command an arsenal of vehicles, weapons and even a killer grappling hook, leaving a country in smoking ruins at the end. Saddam wasn't half as bad...

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Rico Rodriguez reprises his role as a CIA operative in the sequel to Just Cause—the 2006 sandbox-style action game developed by Avalanche Studios. This time around his mission takes him to the fictional island country of Panau situated in Southeast Asia. The mission is to destabilize the newly instated government led by a certain Baby Panay. Working undercover as a hired gun, Rico works with three other factions in Panua that are just as keen to usurp the incumbent government's rule.

The game's paper-thin plot unfolds like a typical US black-ops mission that is often discussed in the fringes of political debate, but never in the mainstream. Cash earned can be used to purchase equipment and vehicles from the agency. These vehicles and weapons can be upgraded by spending upgrade

parts that are scattered across the map. Alternatively, the player can also jack any vehicles from the game-world that are not available for purchase.

The game-world is huge and there is an impressive variety of transportation means with a plethora of ground-based vehicles, motorboats, helicopters and airplanes. The player can even hijack and fly around in a Boeing 747! For a more unconventional mode of transportation, the player can use the combination of Rico's trademark grappling hook and parachute to slingshot across the map. This method – if used effectively – is one of the fastest ways of getting around with maximum mobility.

The grappling hook is invaluable even in combat as it can be used in a variety of ways to quickly turn the tide of a battle in your favour. For instance, when the player is on foot and is pursued by a helicopter, one can grapple onto the hull of the chopper and subsequently take control of the craft.

Side-mission are littered across the map and new ones appear as the game progresses. While most of these side-missions may appear similar at first-glance, it is impressive to see that the level design and enemy types keeps things fresh and challenging.

Compared with the choice of vehicles, the game has limited arsenal of weapons. However, in all fairness it is adequate to carry out any type of mission.

Avalanche studio has used an improved version of the engine that they used to develop the first game in the series and the result is mostly positive. The load-times are impressively low and the textures scale very well without any 'popping-in' effect or noticeable drop in the frame-rate. However, the game suffers from occasional clipping errors. Another area where the developers could have done a lot better is with the game's script and voice-acting. The whole game takes around 20 hours to finish, and a roller coaster ride it is.

In my experience, sandbox games are fun to begin with, but just as easy to lose interest in. Just Cause 2 is one of the exceptions as it manages to keep you engaged and interested right till the end and beyond. **d**